

Spiritual Practice and Realization

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The question: What is realisation, what practice leads to it, and how would anyone know it had occurred? How does Madhyasth Darshan's answer compare with Advaita Vedanta's path of knowledge, and with what modern philosophy and contemplative science have established about practice and religious experience?

This study examines *anubhav* — realisation — and the practice Madhyasth Darshan holds leads to it, and compares that account with **Advaita Vedanta**, whose path of knowledge is its nearest and most demanding rival, and with **modern Western philosophy and contemplative science**, which turn out to have a great deal to say about this subject and not what one might expect.

The relevance of modern philosophy is worth stating in advance, because the natural assumption is that spiritual practice lies outside its range. It does not. Ancient philosophy was itself organised around spiritual exercises, as Hadot's work established; the epistemology of religious experience is a developed field; the perennialist–constructivist dispute is exactly the question of whether contemplative states have content independent of the tradition that trains them; L. A. Paul's account of transformative experience formalises the problem of appraising a state one has not undergone; and contemplative science has produced both suggestive findings and a serious methodological reckoning. Each bears directly on claims the darshan makes.

[The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.8 states the transmission and evidence conditions in outline and §§7.1–7.5 records the resulting evidential problems; [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.13 sets out realisation in coexistence as an activity of *jeevan*. This study takes the practice itself as its subject: what is done, what is claimed to result, and what would count as knowing that it had.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of contemplative practice is hard to avoid: **it looks like the cultivation of unusual brain states** whose content is supplied by the tradition doing the training, valuable perhaps for wellbeing but epistemically inert. Neuroscience and psychology are powerful on mechanism and measurement; yet whether any such state can put someone in contact with how things are, and how a first-person report could ever be cross-checked, remain unresolved. The standpoint taken here does not treat those questions as settled in favour of the view that practice yields experience but never knowledge.

The work begins where that picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with **Advaita Vedanta**, **modern Western philosophy** (the epistemology of religious experience, philosophy as a way of life, and transformative experience), and **the natural sciences** (contemplative neuroscience and its methodological critique). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that realisation is the understanding of existence as coexistence, reached by *jeevan* through study, experiment, and practice, and evidenced in behaviour, work, and the capacity to convey it. It denies that any absorbed state is itself a knowing, and it says so on the strength of its founder's report that he attained such a state and found nothing in it. That denial is the hinge of the whole account, and it is what separates this darshan most sharply from the traditions it emerged from.

1.1 What realisation is

Realisation has a definite object and a definite location. MVD's glossary gives it as realisation in the ultimate truth which is in the form of coexistence, and distinguishes contemplation as the awareness of truth (MVD, p. 316). Realisation is an activity of *jeevan* in the harmony of *buddhi* and *atma*, not a state of the body and not an event befalling a person from outside ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.13).

What is realised is not private. The darshan holds that study is oriented to realisation from the start — “The study is in, by and for realisation in coexistence” (MVD, p. 35) — and that what is realised can be stated, taught, and lived. This is why the darshan has no category of the ineffable: whatever cannot be conveyed has not, on its account, been realised.

1.2 Samadhi without knowing

The account of practice begins with a negative finding reported in the first person. Shri A. Nagraj records that he was assured by the scholars and sages of his time that the only way to know the unknown is *samadhi*, accepted this, went to Amarkantak, and practised from 1950 with maturity in the 1960s (MVD, p. 7). The result is stated without hedging:

“In 1970, I accepted that I had attained samadhi. In this state, my hopes, thoughts, and desires were silent, and it was clear that the event of ‘knowing the unknown’ did not occur.”

— MVD, p. 7

JV gives the fuller version and the reasoning that followed:

“I did not get answers from understanding Vedanta, and I did not get answers after achieving samadhi.”

— JV, p. 13

“There was nothing to describe in the state of samadhi; how could I present its evidence?”

— JV, p. 13

Two distinct claims are being made, and they should not be run together. The first is phenomenological: in *samadhi* hope, thought, and desire fall silent and no cognitive event occurs. The second is evidential: because there is nothing in the state to describe, the state cannot serve as evidence of anything, including of itself. The second is the more consequential, and it is a demand for public checkability made from inside a contemplative tradition rather than against it.

1.3 *Samyama*, and an inverted ladder

What Nagraj reports as productive is *samyama*, and he is explicit that his *samyama* is not the received one. JV cites Patanjali’s definition — *dharana*, *dhyana*, and *samadhi* practised on one object — and then departs from it:

“I could not agree with what was written about samyama. Hence, I devised my own design and method of samyama and subsequently carried it out.”

— JV, p. 13

MVD states the design, and its order is the striking part:

“Of my own accord, I accepted the sequence of samadhi, dhyana, and dharana as the process for samyama. Two years later, having accomplished samyama, I accepted the evidence of having attained samadhi.”

— MVD, p. 7

Patanjali’s sequence ascends from holding to absorption; this one runs the other way, from absorption back through attention to holding. The reversal fits the diagnosis in §1.2: if the absorbed state is silent and contentless, it cannot be the terminus, and what is needed is a return from it into directed attention where something can be examined and stated. MVD reports the outcome as realisation that all existence is in the form of coexistence, presented in literary form for study (MVD, p. 7), and JV reports it

as reaching a state where the understanding can be imparted, together with seeing the *jeevan* atom and the three stages of wanting to live, to be happy, and to evidence oneself (JV, p. 14).

Whether the inversion is a methodological discovery or a redescription of what happened to one person cannot be settled from the texts, and §6.1 returns to it. What can be said is that the darshan does not present *samyama* as traditional authority: it presents it as a method its author devised because the received one did not satisfy him.

1.4 Mystery, and what eradicates it

The darshan names its target *rahasya*, mystery, and defines it as a deficiency of understanding rather than a property of reality:

“Not revealing understanding or not being able to do so, or not being able to attain it, is a mystery. The incapacity for this is ‘mysteriousness’.”

— MVD, p. 273

MVD elsewhere puts it as the incompleteness in understanding the absolute state and the activity, and states the remedy in the same place: eradication of mystery is only through the holistic view of reality, which leads to certitude, in whose absence doubt persists through indecisive tendency (MVD, p. 209).

This is a substantive commitment about the goal of practice, and it is not the goal most contemplative traditions state. The aim is not union, not dissolution of the self, not the cessation of suffering as such, and not an encounter. It is the removal of a cognitive deficit — with the further claim that removing it is what makes continuous happiness possible, since a deluded *jeevan* keeps yearning for a happiness the five senses cannot supply (MVD, p. 274).

1.5 Study, experiment, and practice

The positive method is stated in ordinary terms. Chapter 17 holds that humans alone have the capacity to attain complete understanding through the realisation-based way in coexistence, and that an awakened human evidences their awakening by paving the path for deluded humans (MVD, p. 273). MVD reports that humans have undertaken studies, experiments, explorations, and practices for realisation, reflected in humaneness and higher humaneness (MVD, p. 302), and that the study and practice of mediative activity — *atma* — as presented by this darshan leads to integrality, integrality being justice, *dharma*, and truth-based behaviour, thought, and realisation (MVD, p. 303).

Experimentation is defined as the endeavour continued until success is achieved (MVD, p. 56), which places practice under an ordinary success condition rather than a devotional one. The vocabulary throughout is that of study and trial, and the criterion is integrality across behaviour, thought, and realisation together — not any one of the three.

1.6 Upasana redefined

The one traditional practice term the darshan keeps and rebuilds is *upasana*. MVD and JV report its inherited sense as devotional practice towards deities, or ritual (MVD, p. 4; JV, p. 9). *Manav Karm*

Darshan Chapter 2 assigns it a different content altogether:

“Upasana itself is the process of refining and transforming the root tendencies. This very study is also the transformation of sanskar and essential nature.”

— KD, p. 30

“Wisdom — that is, the human goal — and jeevan-value — that is, resolution [and] prosperity — is itself the direct result of upasana, in which sociality remains naturally contained.”

— KD, p. 37

The chapter is consistent about what follows. *Upasana* is education and orderliness in its own nature (KD, p. 42); its chief utility lies in immersion in universal values (KD, p. 35); at the root of all *upasanas* the aim is undivided society and universal orderliness (KD, p. 35); *upasanas* exist only for capacity-for-awakening, not for decline (KD, p. 36); and symbol-directed *upasana* is judged secondary and unsocial to the extent of its incompleteness, because in it the human goal is neither clarified nor attained (KD, p. 42).

The consequence is that practice in this darshan has no private phase. Because sociality remains naturally contained in *upasana*, there is no stage at which the practitioner withdraws from relationship in order to advance and returns afterwards. [Family Relationships and Values](#) §1.4.2 draws the family-scale consequence: the practice begins in the relationships one is born into.

1.7 Yog is not a discipline in this vocabulary

A terminological point prevents a predictable misreading. *Yog* in Madhyasth Darshan is an ontological term, not the name of a practice: it refers to union, of which there are two kinds, unification and togetherness (MVD, p. 42). Related terms are built on the same root — *sanyog* for coming together, *prayog* for experimentation (MVD, pp. 43, 56).

So when this darshan uses *yog*, it is describing how units come together, not prescribing a discipline. A reader carrying the modern sense of “yoga” into these passages will find prescriptions that are not there. The darshan’s practice vocabulary is *adhyayan*, *prayog*, *abhyas*, *upasana*, and *samyama* — study, experiment, practice, tendency-refinement, and the redesigned method of §1.3.

1.8 Two paths

For a person who is not the discoverer, MVD states the alternatives:

“Such a process is of two kinds: One - Exploration. Two - Following, Emulation, Study.”

— MVD, p. 280

Exploration is described as an inventive realisation which the seeker studies comprehensively — from the initial state of activity or the extreme of decline through to the highest development and awakening (MVD, p. 280). The second path is the ordinary one: following an awakened person, emulating

conduct, and studying. [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.8 notes that MVD further requires delusion-less knowledge, just behaviour, resolved thought, and a disciplined relation to a realised teacher (MVD, pp. 273–285, 317).

The second path is what almost every practitioner is on, and it is where the darshan's epistemology is most exposed. Emulation transmits conduct efficiently; it does not by itself establish that what is emulated is true. The darshan's own resource here is that understanding must be conveyable and testable in one's own living, not that the teacher is authoritative — but the requirement of a disciplined relation to a realised teacher sits uneasily beside that, and §6.4 takes it up.

1.9 What practice repairs

The darshan locates the defect practice addresses with unusual precision. *Jeevan* has five indivisible strengths — *mun*, *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma* — corresponding to hope, thought, desire, resolve, and realisation (MVD, p. 275). Under delusion, hope in *mun* is based on sensation, thought in *vritti* follows that hope, desire in *chitta* follows that thought, and the alienation of *buddhi* from *atma* produces deluded visualisation and desire (MVD, p. 275).

Practice therefore is not the accumulation of states but the repair of a circuit: reflection reaching *buddhi* and *atma* so that realisation and resolve can project outward as coherent visualisation, analysis, selection, and conduct ([The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) §1.4). Bliss is named as the harmony of *buddhi* and *atma* — not a reward for practice but the name of the repaired relation ([Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.2.2). Cognisance or realisation in coexistence becomes evident as resolution, which manifests as the taste of values, evidencing continuous happiness and regulation of the senses through cognisance (MVD, p. 274).

1.10 How realisation is evidenced

Because the darshan refuses to let an inner state serve as its own credential (§1.2), it needs external marks, and it names three. Understanding must be conveyable: “The proof of our comprehension lies in our ability to convey it to others” (JV, p. 26). Conduct must change: integrality is justice, *dharma*, and truth-based behaviour, thought, and realisation together (MVD, p. 303). And the change must be reproducible in tradition — an awakened human evidences awakening by paving the path for others (MVD, p. 273).

This is a demanding standard and the darshan's strongest methodological asset. It rules out the private certainty on which most first-person contemplative claims rest. It also creates the study's central difficulty, since conveyability and conduct are evidence of *something* without being evidence that the content conveyed is true — a person may teach coherently and live well on a false ontology.

1.11 The circle the darshan states itself

MVD sets out the dependencies of realisation without concealing that they close:

“The ability of realisation in knowledge depends on human awakening; human awakening depends on sanskars; development of sanskars depends on environment, study & endeavour; environment, study & endeavour depend on humaneness and higher humaneness; humaneness and higher humaneness depend on the ability of realisation in knowledge.”

— MVD, p. 290

Read as a chain of justification this is circular. Read as the darshan appears to intend it, it describes a system whose parts rise or fall together, in which no single member can be secured first and progress is the coherent improvement of all of them. The second reading is available and is consistent with the account of *sanskara* as the cause of awakening ([Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.5.2). What it does not provide is an entry point for someone in whom none of the members is yet functioning, and §6.2 pursues that.

1.12 What the darshan rejects

The account is defined as much by exclusion as by prescription, and the exclusions are stated plainly. Mystery-based idealistic contemplation failed to accomplish the study of the human being, as did materialism-centred ideology (MVD, p. 3). Renunciation, non-accumulation, detachment, and devotion have drawn immense courage and dedication and produced no undivided society (JV, p. 105). Seeking refuge in God as the real father and mother yields no tangible good — “After seeking refuge in the ‘real mother and father,’ no human is found” (JV, p. 57). Symbol-directed *upasana* is secondary and unsociable to the extent of its incompleteness (KD, p. 42). And the absorbed state itself yields no knowing (§1.2).

Taken together these leave a narrow path: study of a stated system, experiment and practice, refinement of tendency, repair of the faculties, and evidence in relationship and conduct. The darshan removes almost every traditional shortcut, including the one its founder was told was the only way.

1.13 Method, evidence, and what Madhyasth Darshan establishes

Separating the kinds of claim matters here more than in most of these studies, because the founder’s report does evidential work throughout.

Some claims are **first-person historical report**: that *samadhi* was attained and contained no knowing event; that *samyama* was redesigned and produced realisation of coexistence (MVD, pp. 4, 7; JV, pp. 12–14). These are testimony about how the system arose — strong evidence of what one careful practitioner found, and no evidence that others would find the same.

Some are **definitional within the system**: realisation as realisation in the ultimate truth in the form of coexistence (MVD, p. 316); mystery as incapacity to attain or convey understanding (MVD, p. 273); *upasana* as refinement of root tendencies (KD, p. 30); *yoga* as union (MVD, p. 42).

Some are **methodological prescriptions** that could be followed and reported on: the two paths (MVD, p. 280), study and practice of mediative activity (MVD, p. 303), experimentation continued to success (MVD, p. 56).

And one is a **negative epistemic claim of general force**: that a contentless absorbed state cannot serve as evidence. This is the darshan's most transferable contribution, and it does not depend on accepting anything else in the system.

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta holds that liberation is not produced by practice at all, because it is not a state to be attained. What practice does is remove the ignorance that obscures what is already the case. Every feature of its path follows from that, and it makes Advaita the sharpest possible contrast to a darshan whose founder went looking for an event and reported not finding one.

2.1 Moksha as eternally accomplished

Shankara's *Brahma Sutra Bhashya* treats liberation as eternally accomplished, obscured by *avidya*, and disclosed by knowledge. The self is not altered by realisation; the superimposition of self and not-self is removed, which is the subject of the *Adhyasa Bhashya* prefacing the commentary. Because the goal is not produced, practice cannot be its efficient cause — a point Advaita presses against ritualist and yogic accounts alike.

This is the deepest structural agreement and disagreement with Madhyasth Darshan at once. Both deny that an achieved state is the goal. Advaita denies it because the goal was never absent; the darshan denies it because the state was found empty and the goal lies in understanding that can be stated and lived.

2.2 Qualification before instruction

Advaita is exacting about what a seeker must bring. The *sadhana-chatushtaya* comprises discrimination between eternal and non-eternal (*viveka*), dispassion (*vairagya*), the six treasures beginning with tranquillity and self-restraint, and the intense desire for liberation (*mumukshutva*); the *Vivekachudamani* sets out these qualifications and the supporting virtues (vv. 17–20, 69, 82). The Gita's list of divine qualities serves the same preparatory function (16.2–16.3).

The role is precise: these qualify a person to receive teaching and do not themselves constitute knowledge. Advaita therefore has a two-stage structure — become fit, then be taught — with an explicit account of what fitness consists in. Madhyasth Darshan has capacity, ability, and receptivity as conditions of fulfilment but does not organise them into a gate before instruction.

2.3 Hearing, reflection, and sustained contemplation

The path proper is *shravana*, *manana*, and *nididhyasana* — hearing the teaching from a qualified teacher, reasoning it through until doubt is removed, and sustained contemplation until it is no longer merely understood but immediate. The Brihadaranyaka's instruction to Maitreyi is the classical locus (BU 2.4.5). *Sruti* is the means of knowledge for what perception and inference cannot reach, with reasoning subordinate and confirmatory.

The negative discipline is *neti neti* — not this, not this (BU 2.3.6) — and the identification is *tat tvam asi* (CU 6.8.7). What removes ignorance is a knowledge event mediated by language, which is why Advaita can be uncompromising about scripture while remaining unimpressed by absorption.

2.4 The disputed status of *samadhi*

Advaita's own position on absorbed states is more divided than popular accounts suggest, and the division matters for the comparison. Shankara subordinates *yoga* to knowledge: *samadhi* may steady the mind but does not by itself remove ignorance, since what removes ignorance is knowledge and nothing else. Later texts within the tradition are warmer — the *Vivekachudamani* praises absorption and treats it as near-indispensable, and its authorship is disputed for this among other reasons. The *Mandukya* material on the fourth state, *turiya*, describes a condition beyond waking, dream, and deep sleep (MU, vv. 3–7), which is not the same as recommending a technique for reaching it.

So Nagraj's finding in §1.2 does not straightforwardly refute Advaita. On Shankara's own account, that *samadhi* contained no knowing event is what one should expect. Where the traditions genuinely part is on what does the work instead: for Advaita, *sruti*-mediated knowledge culminating in immediacy; for the darshan, a redesigned *samyama* followed by storable understanding tested in conduct.

2.5 After realisation

The *jivanmukta* continues to act, and the Gita supplies the account: prescribed action without attachment to fruit (3.8), and action for the holding-together of the world (3.20, 3.25–26). Conduct expresses realisation without being its cause or its evidence in the darshan's sense. Advaita does not require the liberated person to establish an order, transmit a system, or produce social outcomes, and it does not treat failure to do so as counting against realisation.

2.6 Method, evidence, and what Advaita establishes

Advaita's method is scriptural testimony for the supersensible, disciplined reasoning against it, and contemplation to make it immediate, with qualification as a precondition. Its enduring achievements here are two: the argument that nothing produced can be the final good, hence no state is liberation; and a rigorous account of how a knowledge event, rather than an experience, could remove ignorance. What it does not offer, by its own lights, is public evidence of realisation — the criterion is internal, and the tradition accepts this rather than treating it as a gap.

3. Modern Western Philosophy and Contemplative Science

The subject is not outside modern philosophy's range; it has been worked on from several directions, and the results are unusually relevant to the claims in §1.

3.1 Philosophy as spiritual exercise

Hadot's *Philosophy as a Way of Life* argued that ancient philosophy was not primarily a body of doctrine but a set of *spiritual exercises* — attention, meditation on death, examination of conscience,

memorisation of precepts — whose aim was the transformation of the practitioner. Doctrine served practice rather than the reverse. Foucault's late lectures on the care of the self and *askesis* develop the same material toward techniques of self-formation.

This displaces the assumption that “spiritual practice” names something religious and other than philosophy. It also supplies the closest Western structural analogue to the darshan's position: study whose point is transformation, doctrine that is not idle, exercises that are not withdrawal from the world. Hadot's ancients, like this darshan, treat the philosophical life as continuous with conduct in the city rather than as preparation for leaving it.

3.2 Religious and mystical experience: perennialism against constructivism

James's *Varieties of Religious Experience* established the field by treating such experiences as data with describable marks — ineffability, noetic quality, transiency, passivity — and by taking their fruits as the test of their worth. Stace's *Mysticism and Philosophy* argued for a common core across traditions, distinguishing extrovertive from introvertive mysticism and treating the latter as a contentless unity underlying diverse interpretations. Katz's “Language, Epistemology, and Mysticism” reversed this: there are no unmediated experiences, and a tradition's concepts shape the experience itself, not merely its report. Forman and others replied by defending a pure consciousness event stripped of content.

The dispute bears directly on the darshan's negative finding. Nagraj reports a state in which hope, thought, and desire were silent, nothing occurred, and nothing could be described — which is close to what perennialists describe as a pure consciousness event, and precisely what a constructivist would predict a Vedically trained practitioner to reach and to find unhelpful. That the same report can be read as evidence for either position shows how little a phenomenological description settles.

3.3 The epistemology of religious experience

Alston's *Perceiving God* is the most developed defence of the idea that experience of God can be a source of justified belief, arguing that “mystical perceptual practice” is not shown unreliable merely because it lacks the cross-checking available to sense perception, and that demanding such checks begs the question. The standard objections are the absence of independent verification, the diversity of incompatible reports across traditions, and the difficulty of specifying reliability conditions.

Madhyasth Darshan sits at an odd angle to this literature. It agrees with the critics that a contemplative state without describable content cannot be evidence — indeed it says so more sharply than the critics do. But it then claims realisation with statable content and offers conveyability and conduct as the cross-checks Alston is accused of lacking. Whether those checks are the right kind is §4.4's question.

3.4 Transformative experience

Paul's *Transformative Experience* formalises a problem the contemplative traditions have always faced without naming it. Some experiences are *epistemically* transformative: one cannot know what they are like, or what one will value afterwards, without having had them. Decisions about whether to

undergo them therefore cannot be made by ordinary expected-value reasoning from present values, because the relevant values are among the things that change.

This is precisely the structure of a call to practice. The darshan's demand that understanding be conveyable before it is accepted is an attempt to escape it — to make the case in terms available to the unawakened. Paul's analysis suggests why that is hard: if realisation changes what one counts as evidence and what one values, the pre-realisation assessment cannot be authoritative and the post-realisation assessment cannot be neutral. Advaita's qualification requirement (§2.2) is the same problem handled by admission criteria rather than by argument.

3.5 Contemplative science and its reckoning

Empirical work on meditation has established real effects and has also undergone a methodological correction that matters more than the effects. Neuroimaging has found trait and state differences in long-term practitioners, and clinical trials support moderate benefits for some conditions. But Van Dam and colleagues' "Mind the Hype" documented systematic problems across the field — inconsistent definitions of mindfulness, weak or absent active controls, small samples, and publication bias — and Lindahl and colleagues' study of the varieties of contemplative experience catalogued a wide range of adverse and destabilising effects in Western Buddhist practitioners, effects that traditional literatures acknowledge and modern secular programmes had largely omitted.

Two conclusions bear on this study. Contemplative practice demonstrably changes people, so a tradition claiming transformation is not making an empty claim. And nothing in this literature reaches the epistemic question: measuring that a practice alters attention, affect, or self-report says nothing about whether the resulting understanding is true. The science can corroborate the darshan's claim that practice transforms and is structurally unable to corroborate its claim that the transformation is a knowing.

3.6 Method, evidence, and what modern work establishes

Modern philosophy establishes that transformation-oriented practice belongs to philosophy's own history rather than outside it; that no description of a contemplative state settles whether its content is given or constructed; that the demand for cross-checking is reasonable but not obviously decisive against experiential justification; and that appraising transformative experience from outside is structurally difficult. Contemplative science establishes that practice has measurable effects, that the field's early claims outran its methods, and that adverse effects are real. None of it establishes what realisation is or whether anyone has attained it.

4. Comparison

4.1 Criteria for comparison

The three positions are compared on seven questions: what the goal is; whether practice produces it; what the decisive means is; the status of absorbed states; what counts as evidence of attainment; the place of conduct and relationship; and what happens to the world afterwards.

4.2 Cross-tradition summary

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern philosophy and science
The goal	Realisation of existence as coexistence; eradication of mystery	<i>Moksha</i> — recognition of what is eternally the case	No settled goal; transformation of the practitioner is the studied phenomenon
Does practice produce it	Yes — study, experiment, practice, and <i>samyama</i> lead to it	No — practice removes ignorance; the goal is unproduced	Practice produces measurable change; whether it produces knowledge is untouched
Decisive means	Redesigned <i>samyama</i> , then study and practice of mediative activity	<i>Sruti</i> -mediated knowledge made immediate by contemplation	Spiritual exercises (Hadot); no consensus on epistemic means
Absorbed states	Silent and contentless; cannot serve as evidence	Steadying at most; Shankara subordinates them to knowledge, later texts warmer	Contested between perennialist and constructivist readings
Evidence of attainment	Conveyability, integrality of conduct, reproducibility in tradition	Internal; no public criteria offered	Behavioural and neural measures of change; no measure of truth
Conduct and relationship	Constitutive — sociality naturally contained in <i>upasana</i>	Expressive — <i>loka-sangraha</i> , neither cause nor evidence	Central for Hadot's ancients; peripheral in contemplative science
The world afterwards	Real; to be ordered through undivided society	<i>Mithya</i> at the final level; engagement continues without ultimate standing	Not addressed

4.3 The status of the absorbed state

This is where the comparison is most instructive, because the apparent clash is smaller than it looks and the real one is elsewhere. Nagraj's report that *samadhi* contained no knowing event is not a refutation of Shankara, who holds that knowledge and not absorption removes ignorance. Both are against the same target: the idea that an achieved state is itself the goal.

The genuine divergence is over what replaces it. Advaita replaces it with a knowledge event whose means is scriptural testimony made immediate by contemplation, and accepts that the criterion of success is internal. The darshan replaces it with a method its founder devised, whose product is a statable system, and insists the criterion of success is external — conveyability and conduct. So the traditions

agree in their negative diagnosis and differ completely on what a positive means may consist in, and on whether realisation owes anyone public evidence.

4.4 What could count as a check

All three positions face the cross-checking problem and answer differently. Advaita accepts an internal criterion and is consistent in doing so. Alston argues that demanding sense-perception-style checks of mystical practice begs the question. The darshan uniquely tries to supply external checks — but the ones it supplies underdetermine what they are meant to establish. That a person can convey an understanding, live with integrality, and found a tradition is evidence of competence, coherence, and effect; it is compatible with the ontology conveyed being false. Nothing in the darshan's evidential apparatus distinguishes a realised teacher of a true system from a coherent teacher of a false one.

This is not a reason to prefer Advaita's internal criterion, which distinguishes nothing at all. It is a reason to say that the darshan's demand for evidence is a real advance in kind while remaining insufficient in force.

4.5 Transformation and the appraisal problem

Paul's analysis (§3.4) applies unevenly across the three, and the unevenness is illuminating. Advaita handles the problem by qualification: the *sadhana-chatushtaya* screens for those already disposed, so the appraisal question is not put to the unprepared. Hadot's ancients handle it by making the exercises continuous with ordinary life, so each step is appraisable from the one before. Madhyasth Darshan takes the second route and pushes it further, requiring that understanding be conveyable to the unawakened at every stage — its strongest anti-esoteric commitment.

The residual difficulty is that the darshan also asks for a disciplined relation to a realised teacher (§1.8) and holds that only awakening yields correct evaluation ([Axiology Value Theory](#) §1.4.6). Those two commitments reintroduce from the other side the asymmetry conveyability was meant to remove.

4.6 Practice as private or social

On this the darshan is the outlier, and it is a genuine contribution. Advaita's path is compatible with solitude and its qualification list is a list of personal virtues. Contemplative science studies individuals and measures individual outcomes. KD's redefinition makes sociality naturally contained in *upasana* (KD, p. 37) and treats *upasana* as education and orderliness in its own nature (KD, p. 42), so relationship is not a field of application but the medium of the practice. Hadot's ancients are the nearest analogue — philosophy practised in the city, with the school as its setting — though even there the exercises are individual and the community supports them rather than constituting them.

5. Critical Review

5.1 Madhyasth Darshan — a demanding standard, resting on one report

Strengths.

- The negative claim in §1.2 is a real epistemic advance and transferable to any tradition: a state with nothing describable in it cannot be evidence, including of itself.
- It is made from the inside, by a practitioner who reached the state he then declined to credit — which insulates it from the objection that critics of contemplative claims have not done the practice.
- The refusal of ineffability is disciplined and consistent. Whatever cannot be conveyed has not been realised, so the tradition produces statable doctrine open to examination.
- Practice has no private phase; sociality is contained in it, which removes the standard problem of reconciling withdrawal with social obligation.
- The dependency circle is stated in the darshan's own words (MVD, p. 290) rather than concealed.
- The exclusions are explicit and costly: absorption, renunciation, ritual, devotion, and mystery-based idealism are all set aside, leaving the account without traditional support it might have claimed.

Weaknesses.

- The founding evidence is a single first-person report, and the productive method is one the founder states he designed himself after rejecting the received account (JV, p. 13). Neither can be independently examined.
- Conveyability and integrality of conduct underdetermine truth (§4.4). The external criteria do not discriminate between a realised teacher and a merely coherent one.
- The requirement of a disciplined relation to a realised teacher pulls against the anti-esoteric commitment that understanding be conveyable to the unawakened.
- The inverted *samadhi–dhyān–dharana* sequence is reported, not argued. Why realisation should occur on the descent rather than the ascent is not explained.
- No account is given of failure. If a diligent student following the second path does not reach realisation, nothing in the texts reviewed indicates what that shows about the student, the teacher, or the system.

Madhyasth Darshan sets the most exacting evidential standard of the three positions here and grounds it on the least examinable foundation.

5.2 Advaita Vedanta — rigorous about the goal, silent about verification

Strengths.

- The argument that nothing produced can be liberation is powerful and unanswered by accounts that make the goal an achievement.
- Subordinating absorption to knowledge anticipates the darshan's negative finding by more than a millennium.
- The qualification structure is explicit about what a seeker must already possess rather than assuming availability on demand.

- *Shravana–manana–nididhyasana* is a genuine account of how a knowledge event, not an experience, could remove ignorance.

Weaknesses.

- The criterion of realisation is internal, so the tradition cannot distinguish realisation from confident self-ascription.
- Dependence on *sruti* limits the argument's reach to those who grant the source's authority.
- The world's *mithya* status leaves conduct expressive rather than evidential, so nothing in a liberated person's life could count for or against the claim.
- The internal dispute over *samadhi* between Shankara and later texts is unresolved, which weakens appeals to "the Advaita position" on practice.

Advaita is the more rigorous of the two traditions about what the goal cannot be, and it declines the question of how anyone else could tell.

5.3 Modern philosophy and science — sharp on the problems, empty on the goal

Strengths.

- Hadot recovered transformation-oriented practice as philosophy's own history, which reframes the whole subject.
- The perennialist–constructivist dispute isolates exactly the question that first-person reports cannot settle.
- Alston forces critics to state why cross-checking should be required rather than assuming it.
- Paul's analysis explains why calls to practice cannot be appraised on the appraiser's current values.
- Contemplative science has corrected itself in public — "Mind the Hype" and the adverse-effects literature are the field policing its own claims.

Weaknesses.

- No convergence on whether contemplative states can justify belief, and each position's answer follows from prior commitments.
- The science measures change and cannot in principle reach the epistemic question, a limit sometimes obscured in how findings are reported.
- The literature is overwhelmingly built on Buddhist-derived and theistic practices, so its categories fit a darshan that rejects both absorption and devotion rather poorly.

Modern work states the problems in this area more clearly than either tradition and offers no account of what realisation would be.

6. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan

6.1 The inverted sequence

MVD reports the *samadhi–dhyān–dharana* order as the process for *samyama* (MVD, p. 7) without saying why that order should work. Three readings are possible: that the absorbed state quiets the sensory circuit so directed attention can operate without interference; that the descent is incidental and the work was done by sustained attention regardless of order; or that the sequence records one person's route without general significance. The first would be a substantive methodological claim and is nowhere argued in the texts reviewed.

6.2 Entry into the circle

MVD, p. 290 states the mutual dependence of realisation, awakening, *sanskara*, environment, study, and humaneness. For someone in whom none is yet functioning, the texts do not say which member can be moved first. The available answer is the second path — following, emulation, and study (MVD, p. 280) — which locates the entry in someone else's already-achieved awakening and therefore does not explain how the first entry occurred, other than by the founder's exploration.

6.3 What conveyability establishes

The strongest evidential requirement is that understanding be conveyable (JV, p. 26). Conveyability establishes coherence, communicability, and pedagogical competence. It does not establish correspondence, and the texts do not distinguish the two. A supplementary criterion is needed if the evidence is to bear the weight placed on it, and §4.4 argues that conduct and tradition do not supply it either.

6.4 Teacher-dependence against anti-esotericism

The requirement of a disciplined relation to a realised teacher (MVD, pp. 273–285, 317) coexists with the claim that understanding must be conveyable to anyone and testable in one's own living. These are consistent only if the teacher's role is entirely pedagogical and carries no evidential weight. The texts do not say that, and the practical difficulty is that a student cannot assess whether a teacher is realised without the understanding the teacher is supposed to impart.

6.5 Failure has no diagnosis

Nothing in the sources reviewed addresses what follows when practice does not produce realisation. Without an account of failure the claim that the method works is not exposed to disconfirmation, and the difference between a method that works for the diligent and one that works for no one is not marked.

6.6 The absence of practice detail

For a study of spiritual practice the surprising feature of the corpus is how little procedural instruction it contains. *Samyama* is named and its sequence given but not described in a way another person could

follow. Study, experiment, and practice are prescribed without a curriculum. This may be deliberate — the darshan's point may be that there is no technique beyond study and conduct — but the texts reviewed do not say so, and a reader wanting to do what Nagraj did has little to go on.

6.7 Adverse effects are not considered

The contemplative-science literature documents destabilising effects of intensive practice (§3.5), and Nagraj's own regime of twelve to eighteen hours daily for years (MVD, p. 7) is intensive by any standard. The texts reviewed contain no cautionary account of what such practice can do to a person. This is not evidence against the darshan, but a modern presentation of it that recommends practice owes readers what the empirical literature knows.

6.8 Translation dependence in the *upasana* material

The redefinition of *upasana* in §1.6 carries much of the positive account of practice, and it comes from KD Chapter 2, available here only in a machine-assisted working translation. The argument would change if the Hindi does not support “sociality remains naturally contained” and the demotion of symbol-directed *upasana*. This material should be verified against the original before the section is relied on.

7. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's account of practice is organised around a refusal. Its founder pursued the method he was told was the only way to know the unknown, reached the state it aims at, and reported that nothing happened in it and that there was nothing in it to describe or present as evidence. Everything else follows: a redesigned *samyama* running from absorption back down through attention; a goal stated as the eradication of mystery rather than union or dissolution; *upasana* rebuilt as the refinement of tendency with sociality contained in it; *yog* retained as an ontological term and not a discipline; and evidence demanded in conveyability, conduct, and reproducible tradition rather than in the practitioner's certainty.

Against Advaita the disagreement is narrower and deeper than it first appears. Both deny that an achieved state is the goal, and Shankara's subordination of absorption to knowledge anticipates the darshan's negative finding. They part on what replaces it — *sruti*-mediated knowledge made immediate, against a self-designed method yielding a statable system — and on whether realisation owes anyone public evidence. Advaita says it does not and is consistent; the darshan says it does, which is the more demanding position and the one that can fail.

Modern philosophy turns out to have a great deal to say. Hadot shows that transformation-oriented practice is philosophy's own inheritance rather than something outside it. The perennialist–constructivist dispute shows that the founder's report of a silent contentless state can be read as evidence for either view, which is a caution about how much any such report can settle. Alston shows that the demand for cross-checking needs defending rather than assuming. Paul explains why a call to practice cannot be appraised on the appraiser's present values — the difficulty the darshan's conveyability requirement is designed to escape and does not entirely escape. And contemplative science establishes

that practice measurably changes people while being structurally unable to establish that the change is a knowing.

The darshan's distinctive contribution is the negative claim, and it is transferable: a contemplative state with nothing describable in it cannot serve as evidence, including of itself. That claim is made from inside the practice by someone who had done it, which is the strongest position from which to make it. Its cost is that the system's positive foundation rests on a single unexaminable report and a method its author devised for himself, and that the external criteria it substitutes for private certainty — conveyability and conduct — establish coherence and competence without reaching truth. The darshan asks for more evidence than its rivals and does not yet have evidence of the kind it asks for.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

Terms in §1

- **Anubhav** — realisation. Realisation in the ultimate truth which is in the form of coexistence (MVD, p. 316); an activity of *jeevan* in the harmony of *buddhi* and *atma*.
- **Gyan-anubhuti** — realisation in knowledge; the same realisation considered as the knowing of coexistence (MVD, pp. 290, 316).
- **Rahasya** — mystery. Not revealing understanding, not being able to, or not being able to attain it (MVD, p. 273); incompleteness in understanding the absolute state and activity (MVD, p. 209).
- **Samadhi** — reported as the state in which hope, thought, and desire fall silent and in which no knowing event occurs (MVD, p. 7; JV, p. 13).
- **Samyama** — in this darshan, the method Nagraj devised after rejecting Patanjali's, run as *samadhi*, *dhyana*, *dharana* (MVD, p. 7; JV, p. 13).
- **Upasana** — in KD's redefinition, the refining and transforming of root tendencies and of *sanskar*, with sociality naturally contained (KD, pp. 30, 37); education and orderliness in its own nature (KD, p. 42).
- **Yog** — union, of two kinds, unification and togetherness (MVD, p. 42); an ontological term, not a discipline.
- **Prayog** — experimentation. The endeavour continued until success is achieved (MVD, p. 56).
- **Chintan** — contemplation. The awareness of truth (MVD, p. 316).
- **Realisation-based way** (*anubhav-moolak vidhi*) — the mode in which an awakened *jeevan* evidences all ten of its activities, and in which teaching is conducted (MVD, pp. 71, 79).
- **Integrity** — justice, *dharma*, and truth-based behaviour, thought, and realisation together (MVD, p. 303).

Terms in §2

- **Moksha** — liberation; eternally accomplished and obscured by ignorance rather than produced.
- **Avidya** — ignorance, whose removal is liberation.

- **Adhyasa** — superimposition of self and not-self, the subject of Shankara’s preamble to the *Brahma Sutra Bhashya*.
- **Sadhana-chatushtaya** — the fourfold qualification: *viveka*, *vairagya*, the six treasures, *mumukshutva*.
- **Shravana, manana, *nididhyasana*** — hearing, reasoning, and sustained contemplation.
- **Turiya** — the fourth state, beyond waking, dream, and deep sleep (MU, vv. 3–7).
- **Jivanmukta** — one liberated while living; conduct expresses realisation without evidencing it.
- **Loka-sangraha** — the holding-together of the world; the ground of continued action (BG 3.20, 3.25–26).

Terms in §3

- **Spiritual exercises** — Hadot’s term for the transformative practices of ancient philosophy.
- **Askesis** — training or discipline of the self; Foucault’s care of the self.
- **Perennialism** — the view that mystical experience has a common core across traditions (Stace).
- **Constructivism** — the view that tradition-specific concepts shape the experience itself, not only its report (Katz).
- **Pure consciousness event** — a contentless state of awareness, defended by Forman.
- **Mystical perceptual practice** — Alston’s term for the doxastic practice of forming beliefs from experience of God.
- **Epistemically transformative experience** — an experience whose character and value cannot be known before undergoing it (Paul).

Editorial Notes

The founder’s report as evidence

§§1.2–1.3 rest on autobiographical passages in MVD and JV. This study treats them as first-person historical testimony about how the darshan arose — strong evidence of what one practitioner found, no evidence that others would find the same — and says so in §1.13 and §5.1 rather than letting them function as demonstration. The Epistemology study takes the same line at its §1.8.

Samadhi in three vocabularies

Samadhi names different things in the three traditions compared here, and this study does not harmonise them. In MVD and JV it is the state Nagraj attained and found empty. In Advaita its status is internally disputed, subordinated to knowledge by Shankara and praised in later texts. In the modern literature it is one of several terms for absorption, with no settled referent across studies. Where §4.3 speaks of “the absorbed state”, that is this study’s neutral term and not a translation of any of the three.

Sadhana and upasana

MVD and JV use *sadhana* for the practice Nagraj pursued and moved beyond, so the word is not used here for the darshan's own recommended practice. *Upasana* is used in KD's redefined sense, with the traditional sense reported where the sources report it (MVD, p. 4; JV, p. 9). The same convention is followed in [Family Relationships and Values](#).

Working translation in the *upasana* material

KD Chapter 2 is available in this repository only as a machine-assisted working translation, and it carries the positive account of practice in §1.6. §6.8 records this as an open problem rather than burying it in a citation note. The KD English covers front matter and chapters 1–3 (see its README).

Modern sources selected for relevance, not coverage

§3 does not survey the philosophy of religion or the psychology of meditation. It selects the four bodies of work that bear on claims made in §1 — practice as philosophy, the content of contemplative states, the justification of experiential belief, and the appraisal of transformative experience — together with the methodological correction in contemplative science. Fuller treatment of religious experience and divinity belongs to *God, Divinity, and the Sacred*.

References

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism, Part 1: Holistic View of Human Behaviour](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: failure of mystery-based idealistic contemplation and of materialism-centred ideology (p. 3); *sadhana*, *samadhi*, and *samyama* resolved upon, and *upasana* as devotional practices towards deities (p. 4); *samadhi* attained in 1970 without the event of knowing, the *samadhi–dhyān–dharana* sequence for *samyama*, and realisation of coexistence (p. 7); chapter list including *Yog*, *Liberation from Suffering*, and *Liberation from Mystery* (p. 31); study in, by, and for realisation (p. 35); *yog* as union, unification and togetherness (p. 42); *sanyog* and impetus (p. 43); experimentation as endeavour until success (p. 56); teaching through the realisation-based way (p. 71); ten activities evidenced through the realisation-based way (p. 79); mystery as incompleteness of understanding, eradication through the holistic view, and certitude (p. 209); Ch. 17 *Liberation from Mystery* — mystery and mysteriousness, the capacity for complete understanding, and the awakened human paving the path (p. 273); the deluded *jeevan*'s yearning, and cognisance as resolution (p. 274); five strengths of *jeevan* and the alienation of *buddhi* from *atma* (p. 275); the two kinds of process, exploration and following-emulation-study (p. 280); requirements for realisation in knowledge (pp. 273–285); the dependency circle of realisation, awakening, *sanskara*, environment, study, and humaneness (p. 290); studies, experiments, explorations, and practices for realisation (p. 302); study and practice of mediative activity leading to integrality (p. 303);

contemplation and realisation in knowledge defined (p. 316); realisation in knowledge and its conditions (p. 317).

- **JV** — Nagraj, A. [Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: *upasana* as rituals in the traditional sense (p. 9); *sadhana* at Amarkantak (p. 12); no answers from Vedanta or from *samadhi*, nothing to describe in *samadhi*, Patanjali's *samyama* cited and rejected, and *samyama* redesigned (p. 13); the outcome — capacity to impart the understanding, the *jeevan* atom, and the three stages of living, being happy, and evidencing (p. 14); proof of comprehension as the ability to convey (p. 26); refuge in God as the real father and mother yielding no human (p. 57); idealism of renunciation, detachment, and devotion producing no undivided society (p. 105).
- **KD** — Nagraj, A. *Manav Karm Darshan* (Madhyasth Darshan, Part 2). [Working English translation; Hindi-English review edition](#). Cited: Ch. 2 on *upasana* — refining and transforming the root tendencies and *sanskar* (p. 30), the aim of all *upasanas* and immersion in universal values (p. 35), *upasanas* only for capacity-for-awakening (p. 36), wisdom and *jeevan*-value as the direct result of *upasana* with sociality naturally contained (p. 37), *upasana* as education and orderliness and symbol-directed *upasana* as secondary and unsociable (p. 42). The translation covers front matter and chapters 1–3 (see its README). The English text is a working translation; the Ch. 2 material carrying §1.6 should be checked against the Hindi.

Advaita Vedanta (primary texts)

- **BSB** — Shankara, Adi. [Brahma Sutra Bhashya](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: the *Adhyasa Bhashya* on superimposition; liberation as eternally accomplished and obscured by ignorance; the subordination of *yoga* to knowledge.
- **BU** — [Brihadaranyaka Upanishad](#). English translation by Swami Madhavananda. Cited: *neti neti* (2.3.6); hearing, reflection, and sustained contemplation (2.4.5).
- **CU** — [Chandogya Upanishad](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: *tat tvam asi* (6.8.7).
- **MU** — [Mandukya Upanishad](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: the three states and *turiya* (vv. 3–7).
- **BG** — [Bhagavad Gita with the Commentary of Shankaracharya](#). English translation by Swami Gambhirananda. Cited: prescribed action without attachment (3.8); *loka-sangraha* (3.20, 3.25–26); divine qualities (16.2–16.3).
- **VC** — [Vivekachudamani](#) (traditionally attributed to Shankara; authorship disputed). English translation by Swami Madhavananda. Cited as a later pedagogical witness: the fourfold qualification and supporting virtues (vv. 17–20, 69, 82); the warmer estimate of absorption.

Related studies in this collection

- [The Epistemology of Coexistence](#) — study, realisation, and transmission (§1.8), the active knower (§1.4), and the evidential open problems (§§7.1–7.5).

- [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) — realisation in coexistence as an activity of *jeevan* (§1.13) and *jeevan*'s faculties (§1.7).
- [Axiology Value Theory](#) — bliss as the harmony of *buddhi* and *atma* (§1.2.2), correct evaluation and awakening (§1.4.6), and *sanskara* as the circuit by which conduct deepens understanding (§1.5.2).
- [Family Relationships and Values](#) — the natal family as where *upasana* is initiated, and its feedback circuit with external behaviour (*vyavahara*) (§1.4.2).
- *God, Divinity, and the Sacred* (Ongoing) — divinity, theism, and the sacred, which §3 deliberately leaves aside.

Modern Western philosophy

- **Alston 1991** — Alston, W. P. [Perceiving God: The Epistemology of Religious Experience](#). Cornell University Press. Cited: mystical perceptual practice and the cross-checking objection (§3.3).
- **Foucault 2005** — Foucault, M. [The Hermeneutics of the Subject: Lectures at the Collège de France 1981–1982](#). Palgrave Macmillan. Cited: care of the self and *askesis* (§3.1).
- **Forman 1990** — Forman, R. K. C. (ed.) [The Problem of Pure Consciousness: Mysticism and Philosophy](#). Oxford University Press. Cited: the pure consciousness event (§3.2).
- **Hadot 1995** — Hadot, P. [Philosophy as a Way of Life: Spiritual Exercises from Socrates to Foucault](#). Blackwell. Cited: spiritual exercises in ancient philosophy (§§3.1, 4.5).
- **James 1902** — James, W. [The Varieties of Religious Experience](#). Longmans, Green. Cited: marks of mystical experience and the test of fruits (§3.2).
- **Katz 1978** — Katz, S. T. "Language, Epistemology, and Mysticism." In [Mysticism and Philosophical Analysis](#), Oxford University Press. Cited: constructivism about mystical experience (§3.2).
- **Paul 2014** — Paul, L. A. [Transformative Experience](#). Oxford University Press. Cited: epistemically transformative experience and the appraisal problem (§§3.4, 4.5).
- **SEP Mysticism** — Gellman, J. "[Mysticism](#)." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: the perennialist–constructivist dispute (§3.2).
- **SEP Religious Experience** — Webb, M. O. "[Religious Experience](#)." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: justification from religious experience (§3.3).
- **Stace 1960** — Stace, W. T. [Mysticism and Philosophy](#). Lippincott. Cited: the common-core thesis and the extrovertive/introvertive distinction (§3.2).
- **Thompson 2020** — Thompson, E. [Why I Am Not a Buddhist](#). Yale University Press. Cited: critique of drawing epistemic conclusions from contemplative neuroscience (§3.5).

Contemplative science

- **Lindahl et al. 2017** — Lindahl, J. R., Fisher, N. E., Cooper, D. J., Rosen, R. K., and Britton, W. B. [“The varieties of contemplative experience: A mixed-methods study of meditation-related challenges in Western Buddhists.”](#) *PLOS ONE*, 12(5), e0176239. Cited: adverse and destabilising effects of practice (§§3.5, 6.7).
- **Lutz et al. 2004** — Lutz, A., Greischar, L. L., Rawlings, N. B., Ricard, M., and Davidson, R. J. [“Long-term meditators self-induce high-amplitude gamma synchrony during mental practice.”](#) *PNAS*, 101(46), 16369–16373. Cited: measurable differences in long-term practitioners (§3.5).
- **Van Dam et al. 2018** — Van Dam, N. T., et al. [“Mind the Hype: A Critical Evaluation and Prescriptive Agenda for Research on Mindfulness and Meditation.”](#) *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 13(1), 36–61. Cited: definitional and methodological problems in the field (§§3.5, 5.3).

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